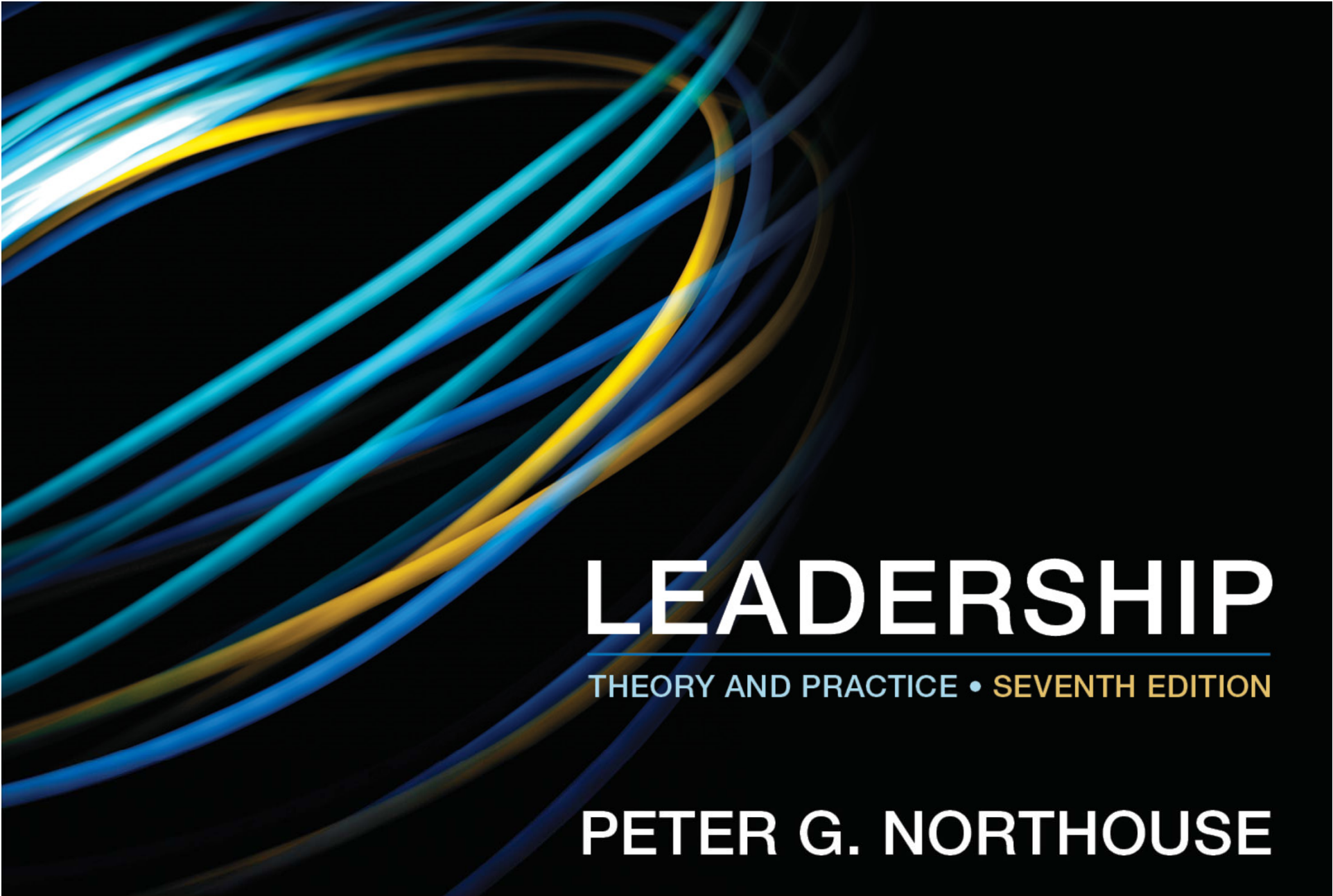




LEADERSHIP

THEORY AND PRACTICE • SEVENTH EDITION

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Chapter 5: Situational Approach

Overview

- ✦ Situational Approach Perspective
- ✦ Leadership Styles
- ✦ Developmental Levels
- ✦ How Does the Situational Approach Work?

Situational Approach Description (Hersey & Blanchard, 1969)

***“Leaders match their style to the competence and
commitment of subordinates”***

Perspective

- ✦ Focuses on leadership in situations
- ✦ Emphasizes **adapting style** - different situations demand different kinds of leadership
- ✦ Used extensively in organizational leadership training and development

Situational Approach Description, cont'd (Hersey & Blanchard, 1969)

Definition

- ✦ **Composed of both a directive dimension & supportive dimension:**
 - ◆ Each dimension must be applied appropriately in a given situation
 - ◆ Leaders evaluate employees to assess their competence and commitment to perform a given task

Leadership Styles

Definition

- ✦ **Leadership style - the behavior pattern of an individual who attempts to influence others**

It includes both:

- ◆ Directive (**task**) behaviors
- ◆ Supportive (**relationship**) behaviors

Leadership Styles

Dimension Definition

- ✦ ***Directive behaviors*** - Help group members in goal achievement via *one-way communication* through:
 - ◆ Giving directions
 - ◆ Establishing goals & how to achieve them
 - ◆ Methods of evaluation & time lines
 - ◆ Defining roles

Leadership Styles

Dimension Definitions

- ✦ ***Supportive behaviors*** - Assist group members via *two-way communication* in feeling comfortable with themselves, co-workers, and situation
 - ◆ Asking for input
 - ◆ Problem solving
 - ◆ Praising, listening

S1 - Directing Style

- ✦ Leader focuses communication on goal achievement
- ✦ Spends LESS time using supportive behaviors

S2 - Coaching Style

- ✦ Leader focuses communication on BOTH goal achievement and supporting subordinates' socioemotional needs
- ✦ Requires leader involvement through encouragement and soliciting subordinate input

S3 - Supporting Style

- ✦ Leader does NOT focus solely on goals; uses supportive behaviors to bring out employee skills in accomplishing tasks
- ✦ Leader delegates day-to-day decision-making control but is available to facilitate problem solving

S4 - Delegating Style

- ✦ Leader offers LESS task input and social support; facilitates subordinates' confidence and motivation in relation to the task
- ✦ Leader lessens involvement in planning, control of details, and goal clarification
- ✦ Gives subordinates control and refrains from intervention and unneeded social support

Development Levels

The degree to which followers have the ***competence*** and ***commitment*** necessary to accomplish a given task or activity

How Does the Situational Approach Work?

- ✦ Focus of Situational Approach
- ✦ Strengths
- ✦ Criticisms
- ✦ Application

Situational Approach

Focus

- ✦ Assumes that subordinates ***vacillate*** along the developmental continuum of competence and commitment
- ✦ Leader effectiveness depends on -
 - ◆ ***assessing*** subordinate's developmental position, and
 - ◆ ***adapting*** his/her leadership style to ***match*** subordinate developmental level

“The situational approach requires leaders to demonstrate a strong degree of flexibility.”

How Does The Situational Approach Work?

Using SLII® model – In any given situation the leader has two tasks:

1st Task

Diagnose the Situation

Identify the developmental level of employee

Ask questions like:

- What is the task subordinates are being asked to perform?
- How complicated is it?
- What is their skill set?
- Do they have the desire to complete the job?

2nd Task

Adapt Style

To prescribed Leadership style in the SLII® model

- Leadership style must correspond to the employee's development level

How Does the Situational Approach Work?

Employee's Developmental Level

- **Competence**
- **Commitment**

Leader's Leadership Style

- **Directive**
- **Supportive**

Strengths

- ✦ **Marketplace approval.** Situational Leadership® is perceived as providing a credible model for training employees to become effective leaders.
- ✦ **Practicality.** Situational Leadership® is a straightforward approach that is easily understood and applied in a variety of settings.
- ✦ **Prescriptive value.** Situational Leadership® clearly outlines what you should and should not do in various settings.

Strengths

- ✦ **Leader flexibility.** Situational Leadership® stresses that effective leaders are those who can change their styles based on task requirements and subordinate needs.
- ✦ **Differential treatment.** Situational Leadership® is based on the premise that leaders need to treat each subordinate according to his/her unique needs.

Criticisms

- ✦ Lack of an empirical foundation raises theoretical considerations regarding the validity of the approach.
- ✦ Further research is required to determine how commitment and competence are conceptualized for each developmental level.
- ✦ Conceptualization of commitment itself and why it varies is very unclear.
- ✦ Replication studies fail to support basic prescriptions of the Situational Leadership® model.

Criticisms

- ✦ Does not account for how particular demographics influence the leader-subordinate prescriptions of the model
- ✦ Fails to adequately address the issue of one-to-one versus group leadership in an organizational setting
- ✦ Questionnaires are biased in favor of Situational Leadership®.

Application

- ✦ Often used in consulting because it's easy to conceptualize and apply
- ✦ Straightforward nature makes it practical for managers to apply
- ✦ Breadth of situational approach facilitates its applicability in virtually all types of organizations and levels of management in organizations